

THE JIO FINANCIAL BLUEPRINT

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WITH THE LISTING OF JIO FINANCIAL SERVICES, RELIANCE CHAIRMAN MUKESH AMBANI HAS LINED UP ALL HIS DUCKS. WILL THE NEW NBFC DISRUPT THE FINANCIAL SPACE THE WAY JIO ROILED MOBILE TELEPHONY DESPITE BEING A LATE ENTRANT?

BY ANAND ADHIKARI • PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH

MUKESH AMBANI
CHAIRMAN &
MD, RELIANCE
INDUSTRIES

IN 2004, JACK MA, the Co-founder of China's Alibaba, an e-commerce business then just five years old and yet to become a world-beater, launched payments platform Alipay for its retail customers and merchants. In a decade, Alipay (later reborn as Ant Financial) became China's leading financial services giant, offering a digital wallet, consumer credit,

money market funds, wealth management, and a digital-only bank for small enterprises. Ant Financial soon had \$600 billion in assets under management as it layered various financial services atop the e-commerce platform. What also worked was China's underserved and unbanked population, with an aspirational middle class—and a surge in

smartphone use. China's financial services sector, dominated by state-owned banks, was also ripe for disruption. Ma had struck gold.

Mukesh Ambani's Jio Financial Services, dubbed the group's 'fourth engine' after oil, telecom, and retail, aims to mirror Ma by leveraging its established consumer-facing businesses: retail and telecom.